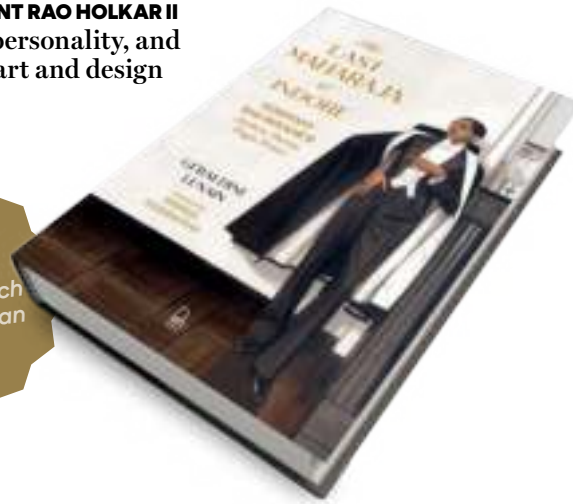
BOOKS ▼

# The Way of Kings

**MAHARAJA YESHWANT RAO HOLKAR II** was a fascinating personality, and a global patron of art and design



**THE LAST MAHARAJA OF INDORE**
By Géraldine Lenain, translated from the French by Sindhuja Veeraragavan
ROLI BOOKS
₹495; 240 pages

History is so much more fascinating than fabricated fiction. Especially when it is told about people, almost at touching distance, and by someone who knows the proximate geopolitics, the foul games of colonialism and the cruel rules of adoration in high society when the wallet is full against when the inflow dries out. Kudos to Géraldine Lenain.

If the Indian god Vishwakarma was given a foot ruler, set squares and a compass to interpret the French design movement of *les Arts Decoratif* into a human being, he couldn't better his hand from his own creation of 1908: Indore's Yeshwant Rao Holkar II, with an almost perfect half-round skull, mildly bow-arched eyebrows, a protruding, triangular aquiline nose, with ears which stood out like the handles of an Art Deco teapot! Cast in this mould, the adolescent Yeshwant became the world's most conspicuous art and design patron.

Young Holkar, who was only 22 when crowned as a Maharaja, lost no time to beat the British in style by relying on German and French avant-garde design movements. But he had been brought up strictly with British public school etiquettes and austerities. When the floodgates of his own wealth opened for him, he outdid the nouveau riche, but with rare good taste, which even European connoisseurs envied. But without a good spiritual, non-materialistic Indian grounding, the Maharaja played Life's game on the terms of the western glitterati. He had custom-made gold and diamond-encrusted skis; his hunting motorhome of 1936 had a bathroom with a tub and an eight-seater dining. He also went on to make a palace on his train valued at €1,200,000 in 2021 and a virtual palace within his plane. His yacht-water palace project was abandoned when he lost his first wife Sanyogita. His second and third wives—a nurse and a socialite, only pulled him in the wrong direction. They made a visionary become a victim of his own excesses. Material lust took precedence, leading to fatal consequences. Compact, racy, fact-filled but evocative, Lenain has produced a near-perfect book. ■

***—Aman Nath***

EXHIBITION ▼

# ROYAL DESIGNS

**A travelling photo exhibition spotlights one of India's earliest icons of modernity**

Maharaja Yeshwant Rao Holkar II of Indore met German architect Eckart Muthesius at a garden party in Oxford in the late 1920s. Soon after, the maharaja commissioned Muthesius to design a palace for him and his wife in Indore. Completed in 1933, Manik Bagh set a precedent for introducing western modern aesthetics in India.

At Mumbai's Dr. Bhau Daji Lad Museum, *Eckart Muthesius and Manik Bagh—Pioneering Modernism in India* tells the story of this Indo-German collaboration. The exhibition shows rare photographs as well as little-known watercolours, drawings and design studies by Muthesius, which highlight the puristic yet innovative interiors of the palace. "Some of these sketches and photographs were exhibited at Mumbai's Town Hall (now the Asiatic Society) in 1934. This was a period of cultural shift in (then) Bombay and was reflected in its evolving art, architecture and design," says Tasneem Zakaria Mehta, managing trustee and director of the museum. The exhibition is on till August 17. ■



***IN MANIK BAGH*** The Maharaja's living room (watercolour on paper) by Eckart Muthesius

***—Prachi Joshi***